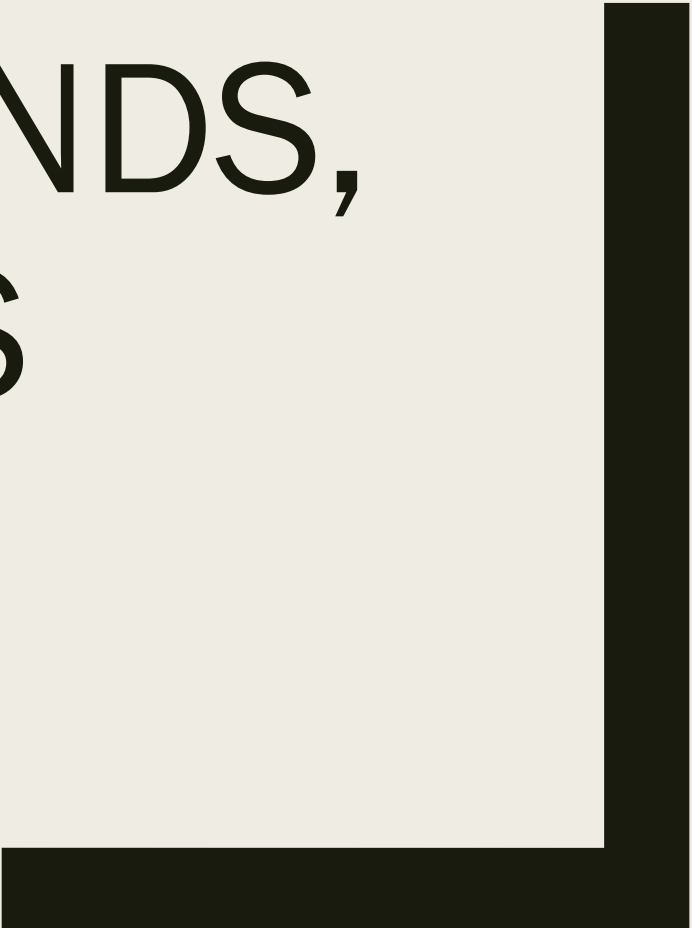




CLAIMS, GROUNDS, WARRANTS

Writing Seminar
Thomas C. Sawyer



THE BASICS



Dissecting Argument

Stephen Toulmin, philosopher, devised an argumentative schema with three primary components:

A **CLAIM** states the purpose of the argument. Think: “thesis” or “the point.”

GROUNDS support the claim: “evidence” or “facts” or “data.”

A **WARRANT** connects claim and grounds: “rationale” or “operating assumption.”

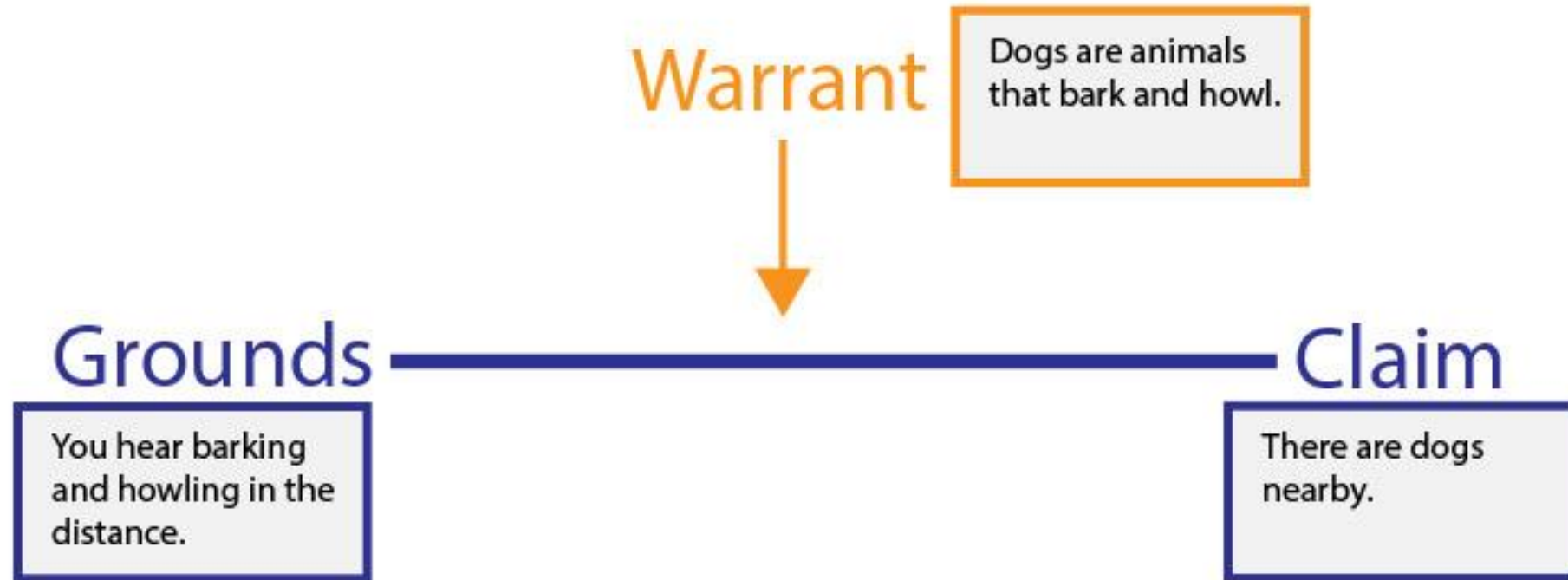
EXAMPLE #1
(Purdue Owl)

CLAIM: There are dogs nearby.

GROUND: You hear barking and howling.

WARRANT: Dogs are animals that bark and howl.

EXAMPLE #1 (Purdue Owl)



HIDDEN WARRANTS

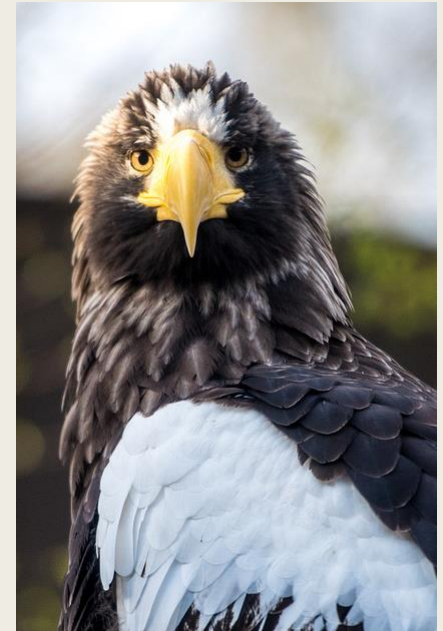
It can take *weeks* to find them



The very big eagle that escaped from the National Aviary in Pittsburgh is back home (Kim Lyons, *The Verge*, 4 October 2021)

Kody is a bird that would be difficult to miss: he's large (although in Pittsburgh we probably wouldn't call him "giant" because "Giant Eagle" is a grocery store chain here), with a yellow beak, white tail and white feathers on the tops of his wings. He's bigger than a bald eagle, and has a wingspan of about six feet.

Kodiak is Stell(e)r



EXAMPLE #2

(Kody, not an Owl)

CLAIM: Kody is a bird that would be difficult to miss[.]

GROUND: [H]e's large . . . with a yellow beak, white tail and white feathers on the tops of his wings. He's bigger than a bald eagle, and has a wingspan of about six feet.

WARRANT: ???

EXAMPLE #2

(Kody, not an Owl)

CLAIM: Kody is a bird that would be difficult to miss[.]

GROUND: [H]e's large . . . with a yellow beak, white tail and white feathers on the tops of his wings. He's bigger than a bald eagle, and has a wingspan of about six feet.

WARRANT: Birds that are large, with yellow beaks, white tail, and white tail feathers, that are bigger than a bald eagle, and that have six-foot wingspans are difficult to miss.

EXAMPLE #2
(Kody, not an Owl)

CLAIM: Kody is a bird that would be difficult to miss[.]

GROUND: [H]e's large . . . with a yellow beak, white tail and white feathers on the tops of his wings. He's bigger than a bald eagle, and has a wingspan of about six feet.

WARRANT: Large birds with distinctive features are difficult to miss.

The very big eagle that escaped from the National Aviary in Pittsburgh is back home (Kim Lyons, *The Verge*, 4 October 2021)

“A Steller’s sea eagle named Kodiak [escaped from its enclosure](#) at the National Aviary in Pittsburgh on September 25th, and thanks to the valiant efforts of the Aviary staff, was found and brought back to the Aviary on Sunday.”

A WEEK! What a distinctively excellent bird at not being found for a week.



THIS
IS
NOT
KODY

PHAEDRUS' WARRANT

What . . . is it?

Plato, *Symposium*, trans. Alexander Nehemas and Paul Woodruff (Hackett, 1989)

All sides agree, then, that Love is one of the most ancient gods. As such, he gives to us the greatest goods. (178C)

EXAMPLE #3
(Phaedrus, a featherless biped)

CLAIM: Love gives us the greatest goods.

FOUNDATIONS: Love is one of the most ancient gods.

WARRANT: ???

EXAMPLE #3
(Phaedrus, a featherless biped)

CLAIM: Love gives us the greatest goods.

GROUND: Love is one of the most ancient gods.

WARRANT: Older gods give greater goods.

Plato, *Symposium*, trans. Alexander Nehemas and Paul Woodruff (Hackett, 1989)

All sides agree, then, that Love is one of the most ancient gods. As such, he gives to us the greatest goods. I cannot say what greater good there is for a young boy than a gentle lover, or for a lover than a boy to love.

(178C)

EXAMPLE #3
(Phaedrus, a featherless biped)

CLAIM: Love gives us the greatest goods.

GROUND: Love is one of the most ancient gods.

???: I cannot say what greater good there is for a young boy than a gentle lover, or for a lover than a boy to love.

ASSIGNMENT

You have one! It is detailed on the last page of the informational PDF.

Please email with any questions: tsawyer@uchicago.edu